

BERNERA NEWS

In association with **The Daily Ceilidh**

Welcome to our second edition of **Bernera News**. In this newsletter, which is being delivered to every home in Bernera and Tir Mor, we've plenty of information and news, as well as some fantastic pieces from the community.

For those of you who missed out on our first newsletter, it is available to view online at thedailyceilidh.co.uk, or for those without access to the internet we are happy to deliver out a copy to you, just get in touch.

Our intention is to produce a newsletter every fortnight throughout the current situation. Our main focus will be on sharing information and news, although we also like to include less formal pieces, something we like to call Postcards from the Islands; short writings about life in Bernera and the surrounding area.

We'd really like for you all to get involved. If you have some news to share, an idea of what else we could be doing, or if you'd like to write a piece for the newsletter we want to hear from you.

We really appreciate all the kind comments and offers of help that we've received so far, but welcome any input so please don't hesitate to get in touch.

Contact us at:

01851 600 159

hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk

Or visit us online at:

www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk

CORONAVIRUS UPDATE

From Friday 29th May, the Scottish Government has announced that there will be some changes to the lockdown regulations. It is important to stress that lockdown has not been lifted, and only small changes have been made to how we can go about our daily lives. However, even small steps can make a big difference.

One of the main changes that has been announced is the ability to meet up with others from outside your household. The guidance clearly states that you should only meet with one other household at a time, ideally to a maximum of 8 people in total.

You should maintain a minimum 2 metre distance between members of different households at all times, and all meetings should only take place outside. Every effort should be made to avoid touching the same hard surfaces as the other household, for example using your own food, cups, plates, etc. The Scottish Government strongly recommend that you don't meet with more than one other household per day.

There have also been changes to the amount of outdoor activity that is now permitted, as well as the types of activity allowed. Non-contact sports, such as golf, outdoor swimming, fishing, canoeing and hiking, can now be undertaken. There is no time limit for these activities, but all should be carried out as safely as possible, and ensuring social distancing is maintained.

It is very much hoped that we will continue to see a downward trend in rates of infection throughout the UK, and that life will slowly return to a more normal position. However, it is important for us not to get complacent. Social distancing and good hygiene, including regular hand washing, should be continued even if you do not perceive there to be a risk.

For full information and guidance we strongly suggest that you keep up to date with information from the Scottish Government, either online www.gov.scot/coronavirus-covid-19, or through the television or radio.

There's also more information available on our website:

www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk/covid

Virginia Allum
Earshader



Support for anyone in the Outer Hebrides who requires assistance whilst self-isolating is being led by Comhairle nan Eilean Siar.

Call the Community Support Hub & Helpline: 01851 600 501

SHOP NEWS

June, Nicola, CJ and Aileen all continue to support the local community in making sure that fresh food is available to all who need it. Their invaluable delivery service is making a huge difference to the lives of so many within the community. If you are unable to get out and about and would benefit from a delivery, please get in touch with them. For those able to get to the shop there remains a limit of 1 customer in the shop at a time, with hand gel provided for use on entrance. Please also observe social distancing rules at all times.

Tel: (01851) 612282 - Opening times are 12 - 5 Mon to Sat, and 1 - 3 (shop only) on Sunday.

BERNERA DOCTOR'S SURGERY

The surgery remains closed at this time, but patients are still able to seek medical advice and support from Langabhat Medical Practice on **(01851) 860222**.

From Monday 25th May they will be increasing the number of face to face appointments at Leurbost, Carloway and Borge. However, these appointments will only be offered where a doctor or nurse has reviewed a patient and decided that they should be seen in the practice. It is important that you do not just turn up at the surgery without a pre-booked appointment, or without being told to do so.

Due to the current situation you are asked to allow at least 72 hours for all prescription requests, although some may be available sooner it cannot be guaranteed. Prescriptions continue to be delivered by the Bernera Community Association team, to whom we are all grateful.



SALVATION ARMY FOOD BANK

Throughout the Covid-19 crisis the local Stornoway Corps have been offering support within the community to those in need. With demand increasing they have now expanded their services, with a 3 hour session being held at Stornoway Golf Club on a Wednesday and a Saturday, from 11am to 2pm.

Fresh fruit and vegetables are available, as well as other food stuffs, for all who may need additional support at this time. Toiletries and household cleaning products are also available. There are even books, DVDs, games and toys to help keep people entertained whilst stuck at home.

The Baby Bank has also moved to the Golf Club, offering additional support to those with young children.

All services are open to everyone. **For more information you can call (01851) 703875**

For anyone wanting to make use of this excellent community service, but without access to transport, please don't hesitate to get in touch with us here at The Daily Ceilidh, in strictest confidence. We will be attending a session once a week, in order to collect anything needed by our local community, for delivery locally.

Sam Millns
Kirkibost



THE ALL SORTS CLUB

The regular Wednesday club meetings have been suspended for the time being and will only start again once advice from the Scottish Government is clear and members feel happy to do so. After all, the safety of our members, and everyone in the community, is paramount to us.

Members are keeping in touch with each other during self-isolation and, where possible, helping with buying and delivering needed items. As most will know we have sold quizzes during the summer in the past to raise club funds, since we cannot do this at the moment we would like to share some that have been prepared for this summer through the Bernera News for your enjoyment.

ALPHABET QUIZ

All answers begin with the letter of the question:

- A. Macedonian King who carved an empire
- B. Nickname of one of the chasers
- C. The cross eyed lion of Daktari
- D. Norman Great Survey of England and parts of Wales
- E. Large biomes set up for the millennium
- F. Chemical used for preserving
- G. Scottish reel for two people
- H. Known as the 'Silver Darlings'
- I. Greek who flew too close to the sun
- J. Katie Price used this pseudonym
- K. Island volcano east of Java
- L. Custer's last stand
- M. Water body separating Stornoway and Ullapool

(SECOND HALF & ANSWERS IN THE NEXT EDITION)

BERNERA HISTORICAL SOCIETY

Currently, both the Museum and Iron Age House are closed due to Covid 19. The trustees are monitoring the Scottish Government's advice and at this time museum opening will be allowed in phase 3, which is likely to be sometime around early August based on the present situation.

However, this will, of course, depend on strict social distancing and hygiene rules being able to be implemented at each location. Volunteers are taking the opportunity to do some work on our archives, and we are sharing photos on a weekly basis on our Facebook page and on our website, these are being warmly received.

We have started a project to collect photos and information about Bernera and Tir Mor WWII servicemen and would ask anyone with such, willing to share with the museum, to let us know and we can collect, scan and return to you. We have one or two other projects in the pipeline and more details of these will follow as we progress with them.

BERISAY ISLAND – LAST HOLDOUT OF NEIL MACLEOD.



Neil Macleod was an illegitimate son of Roderick, the last of the Macleod chiefs of Lewis. Roderick had three legitimate and five illegitimate sons who, before and after his death, fought between themselves, and later with the new lords appointed by King James VI in 1598, 'The Men of Fife'.

Neil and his brother Murdo made life so difficult for these colonists that in 1610 they sold their title, writs and charters to Mackenzie of Kintail for 10,000merks, Mackenzie was a friend and ally of Roderick eldest son Torquil Conanach.

Neil Macleod had used the Island of

Berisay, in Loch Roag off Great Bernera, as a safe haven and stored supplies there for times of need. In 1610 he and a band of followers retreated there to escape from Mackenzie and held out for three years.

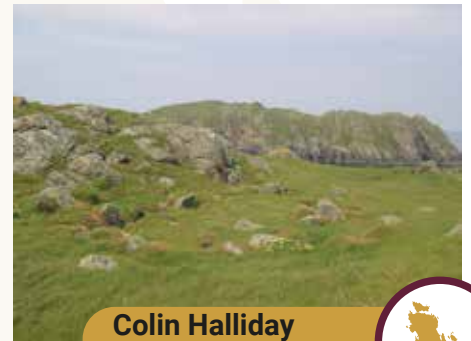
During that time they would raid Mackenzie lands in Lewis and also became successful sea-robbers (or pirates). As Berisay is a natural island fortress the Mackenzies were unable to eject or capture Macleod even though the Privy Council in Edinburgh wanted it so.

In 1613 Mackenzie was about to give up when a final diabolical plan was hatched. His men rounded up wives, children and relatives of the men on Berisay and at low tide rowed them out to a Skerry close to Berisay and left them there to drown as the Skerry would be covered at high tide.

The men on Berisay could not watch these innocents die and so left Berisay and were captured by Mackenzie.

Taken to Edinburgh Neil Macleod faced trial on 30th March 1613, charged with fire-raising, burning, murder, theft and piracy. He confessed to all crimes and was sentenced to be hanged and his head to be struck from his body and set upon a spike above Nether Bow Port. This was carried out in April of that year.

Today on Berisay there can still be seen outlines of rectangular buildings and some traces of earlier circular ones, there is also a man-made rainwater lochan. The island is still difficult to land on with the feel of being the Island Fortress.



Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLAND...

We have been busy making a temporary tree house out of pallets and an old rope for a swing, it was so much fun. I also have been dressing up a lot and mum helped me do my hair and make up. I always get dirty when I have a pretty dress on and sometimes I swim in the sea or loch in it and mum rolls her eyes at me.

Arwen - age 8, Kirkibost



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLAND - DETTA'S DELIGHT!

What on earth is a Bernera girl doing in a Carloway choir, you may well ask?

I was fortunate enough to be invited along by our lovely Angela from Lundale, who had been in the choir for a few years, when I moved back home from Inverness after 31 years living away. I had been thinking about doing something singing related but hadn't found the courage to put myself forward; Luckily Angela took it out of my hands!

Carloway Gaelic choir was set up in 2011, with 14 Members. Today it has grown to a choir of 27, full of very talented individuals who have won Gold & Silver medals at the much loved, annual National Mod.



The rest, as they say, is history! I found the most wonderful choir with the loveliest, funniest people I could ever wish to meet! Our conductor Màiri is exceptionally talented, able to play two parts on the piano, whilst singing another part, and has the patience of a saint! Then there's our Gaelic advisor Iain, who is extremely patient and loves to give us praise when we get things

right, though we are always waiting for the inevitable 'but!..'. He keeps us grounded and gives us a laugh. Laughter is the thing that makes our choir so special. We have so much fun learning our songs and words, which can be pretty challenging a lot of the time, so a bit of light hearted banter makes it far more enjoyable and seems to help the words stick.

And so to present day. We have launched a Justgiving fundraiser with our remotely recorded song 'Càrlabhagh', going live on Youtube which at time of writing had 21.5k views, £1295 raised and numerous shares on social media. Amazing to think of this all from a little idea Màiri had while relaxing in her bath on April 11th!

The entire choir is in shock, we can't believe how generous and kind people have been and the comments about the video are so heartwarming. Thank you from every single one of us, we are truly humbled. Màiri's response to how she feels about doing innovative things is, "At first I was worried that such a thing could work but now I'm just embracing it! Roll on the next song!"

I have a feeling my Great, Great Grandfather would have approved too and this is why it's so fitting that I should end up in the wonderful Carloway choir. You see, he was 'An Tailleir' and he originated from Carloway, so I immediately had such a strong affinity with these wonderful people. The fact they're completely bonkers helps too...

Ps...there's no place like home...Bearnaraigh - Àite Mo Ghaoil.

My Mum and I also thought it would be good fun to pen a Bernera verse..and she did! If anyone would like to see it, let us know... Catriona Davis, songwriter, who knew?!!

www.justgiving.com/crowdfunding/coisirghaidhlig-charlabhaigh

It was great to see so many people enjoying the Choir's video and contributing to their Justgiving page. It was enjoyed by those able to connect digitally and immediately I knew we had to find a way for those without an internet connection to listen and share the moment too. After a bit of thought I settled on building a solution which was free or low cost to use from a landline telephone.

So no matter who you are, you can join in the fun by phoning **0203 481 5235** from your landline and hear the full version of the song that the Carloway Choir has produced.

This will help us test out the service during a 2 week trial, which if successful could be extended to include a thought for the day from Rev Hugh, fellow islanders and other contributors.

Let us know your thoughts. It costs us a few pennies per call but the joy it shares is priceless. Please get involved!

Chrisetta Macleod
Breacleite



Nat Higginbottom
Kirkibost



ON THE SOFA... LOUISE-ANNE MACDONALD, MPOWER

If you are struggling with loneliness and social isolation, the lockdown is probably making everything even more of a challenge; whether due to lack of transportation, no social gatherings, or lack of digital confidence and access, the lockdown is having an increased impact on us all.



Julia asked **Louise-Anne MacDonald, the NHS Community Navigator for Lewis and Harris**, to “pop by” for a virtual chat about how she can help and what it’s been like to start a role with social distancing and lockdown rules in play...

Louise-Anne is one of 3 Community Navigators who cover the Western Isles, and she is excited to be able to focus on each client and their needs in a direct way in her new role.

What is mPower?

mPower is part of the NHS WI and aims to support people living with Long Term Conditions to live well, safely and independently in their own homes.

The service is there to help you if you need general wellbeing and lifestyle support, if you feel lonely or isolated or generally feel low and if you have difficulty heating or looking after your home or meeting your bills.

How do the team or Community Navigators do this?

They start to identify ways they can help through the completion of a personalised wellbeing plan (usually during a home visit appointment), but which will be done via telephone or video chat until social distancing is relaxed. This plan focuses on you being better able to look after your health and wellbeing by connecting you to local activities/services as well as looking at how technology can be used to support you better.

What Louise-Anne has been doing since starting her role?

She has had to jump into the role quickly, learning new ways of doing things remotely, rather than the home or community groups visits which would normally be in place.

She’s been doing courtesy phone calls to check in with current and previous Service users, finding out what their needs are and signposting them to any services like Befriending Lewis, that might be useful.

There has been a rise in the number of users asking about help with sleep issues and they have been able to be helped by getting them onto the Sleepio service, which users can find helpful to manage their sleep related issues. Anyone on the Western Isles can use this service for free by self-referral or can be referred by their GP or family for help by emailing **wi-hb.mpower@nhs.net** or contacting Louise directly.

Louise-Anne said it had been good to support clients with their technical challenges whilst not being able to sit with them, as would be normal practice and that the mPower team was being supported by AbilityNet to support users, finding ways to ensure that they were properly enabled.

If you want to find out more from Louise-Anne and her colleagues, you can contact them for an Information pack which includes a self referral letter, an introduction letter to the Community Navigators and an information leaflet and can be sent out to you in the post.



“Everyone is feeling isolated at the moment and we’re all much more aware of the challenges of loneliness and isolation normally experienced by a smaller section of our Community. We can only hope that it will give us a better empathy and understanding of why social connection is so important to our health and well being.”

Louise Anne finished by saying “It’s rewarding to know that you have helped somebody to connect with others, especially in these anxious times”.

You can contact her via:

mobile: 07966 259060

telephone: 01851 708022

email: louiseanne.macdonald1@nhs.net

Julia Higginbottom
Kirkibost



CONNECTED COMMUNITIES

'Connected Communities' is a term that we have come to know over the past few years. It speaks of communities effectively linking and interacting with one another more closely, more intimately and more inter-relatedly.

That is what was seen last Tuesday, as the community reached out and embraced in love, care and support a grieving family no longer living in Bernera; yet part of it. Proving that geography is unable to breach the spirit of a tight knit, island community.

As I reached the Bernera road end I was met by the family, and then the hearse came into view. Solemnly and discreetly the funeral cortege made its way towards Bernera Bridge passing through Lundale, Crulivig and Earshader continuing on past Dun Innes, Breacleit, Tobson, Croir before arriving at Bosta graveyard.

An unusual and exceptionally moving experience for all concerned and one that will remain in our memory for many days.

What was particularly impressive was the tangible respect, solemnly, silently and graciously expressed by the people of mainland Bernera and Great Bernera towards one of their own.

Remembering the late Chrissy McDonald (nee McLeod) of Breacleit, as they stood at the roadsides and in their gardens whilst the cortege passed by. A tangible evidence of a community reaching out and embracing in love a grieving family.

God also strongly believes in Connected Communities. He too wishes to connect with us individually, through His Son Jesus Christ.

A connection that by God's grace and through faith, is deep and unbreakable.

A connection that not even death, our wrongs or the grave itself can rob us of.

As in the bible Paul declares: **"O Death, where is your sting? O Hades, where is your victory?" 'The sting of death is sin, and the strength of sin is the law. But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ', 1 Corinthians 15:55-57**

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



VIRTUAL SERVICES.

For those of you with access to the internet, Lochs-in-Bernera Church of Scotland offer regular virtual services as listed below.

Online Sunday Service - 10:30 am
(Available on the Church's FB page or Youtube Channel thereafter, further details below.)

Online Sunday School - 12 noon

Online Prayer Meeting - 7 pm each Thursday evening.

Both the online Sunday School and the Prayer Meeting are hosted on video conferencing. They are open to all, please email the Minister at berneralwuig@btinternet.com to receive a secure invitation. Full Safeguarding Protocols are followed in respect of all activities involving children online

The Sunday Service is available on the Church's Facebook page, and from Sunday 17th May from the Church's Youtube Channel, accessible from the Facebook page.

If you would like any technical help and support to enable you to access any of the online services please get in touch with us at The Daily Ceilidh, for free assistance (01851 600 159).

OISEAN A' CHALMAN BANCA PAISDE [DOVE'S WING BABY BANK]

Open to all parents and children residing in Uig, Bernera and Kinloch, through their Facebook page.
24 hr Contact Number – Call or Text 07903 311934 in complete confidence.

PASTORAL CARE

The Minister is available 24/7 to offer pastoral care to anyone in the Parish of Bernera whether or not they come to church.

He may be contacted on: (01851) 672 388 or 07971 057915 or by e-mail at berneralwuig@btinternet.com.

